



LOOK OUT FOR WARNING SIGNS

- 90% teens show extreme reluctance to go to school—a classic symptom
- Over 70% show depressed, irritable mood, ill-temper, feelings of worthlessness, sadness, or self-hatred; inappropriate guilt and acting-out behaviour (missing curfews and unusual defiance)
- Around 40-50% report headaches, loss of appetite and interest in daily activities and distinct weight change
- Over 30% have persistent difficulty falling or staying asleep, excessive daytime sleepiness, fatigue, difficulty concentrating and preoccupation with self
- About 48% think about suicide, have obsessive fears or worry about death and plan to commit suicide or actually attempt one

Source: Child & Adolescent Psychiatry Clinic, AIIMS

read the last note of a student from Bangalore who shot himself in the head.

But what makes teenagers decide that adulthood is not worth waiting for? Until recently, such questions would not have had easy answers. "The idea of children becoming clinically depressed is still relatively new," says Mehta. "Until the 1980s, doctors tended to hold the Freudian view that children are incapable of experiencing depression in the true sense because they don't yet have a developed super-ego." Then in 1999, a new category

surfaced in the annual NCRB listing of deaths and crimes: "Persons below 16 years attempting suicide". That opened up research floodgates and suicide emerged as the most dreaded manifestation for a spectrum of psychiatric disorders roosting among the teens. Diagnosis of adolescent depression has gone up from 0.4 per cent in 1980 to 6.5 per cent in 2005 at the Child and Adolescent Psychiatry Clinic, AIIMS. In India, as many as 12.8 per cent adolescents now suffer from psychiatric disorders, holds the Indian Council of Medical Research.

But what explains the high-levels of depression? By every measure, urban children have much more—clothes, toys, gadgets—than their parents, raised on post-Independence values of thrift and self-sacrifice, ever did. Indian parents spent a whopping Rs 364 crore on their children last year and 40 per cent urban youngsters have computers and mobile phones in 50 per cent Indian homes today, according to Cartoon Network surveys between 2005-07. According to a survey by Swedish research and consulting firm Kairos Future last year, Indian youth is the

What was the fourth point the boss said?

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